



## 1st Graders at ICS Celebrate Reading Festival On-Stage



ICS - K12 SCHOOLS  
INTERNATIONAL EDUCATION



*Excitement and pride filled ICS as our 1st graders took the stage to celebrate their Reading Festival. Marking an important milestone in their learning journey, the students confidently showcased their progress in front of teachers and families.*

*The celebration featured cheerful songs and a short drama performance, highlighting both their reading skills and growing self-confidence. The audience warmly applauded their efforts and enthusiasm.*

*The event concluded with a certificate ceremony, where each student was proudly recognized for their dedication and achievement. It was a joyful and memorable day for the entire ICS community.*

### Reflections on The Self: When Mirrors Speak

What do we see when we look in a mirror? Beyond our faces, mirrors reveal the hidden layers of identity, perception, and the self we are still becoming. From the mystical reflections explored by Mevlana to contemporary artists like Barbara Kruger and Michelangelo Pistoletto, mirrors serve as both tools and metaphors—challenging us to question what is real, what is reflected, and who we truly are. This article delves into the mirror's role in art, philosophy, and human consciousness, inviting readers to reconsider the everyday object that quietly shapes our understanding of ourselves and others.

*Read more on pages 4 & 5.*

### Lessons from an International Life

Growing up in an international school means experiencing the world every day. From classrooms to friendships, different cultures, languages, and traditions become part of daily life. Drawing on experiences in Hungary and the UK, this article explores how cultural understanding, small everyday habits, and shared traditions—like food and language—teach us empathy, connection, and the value of inclusive communities. It's a reminder that learning from one another doesn't just broaden horizons—it brings the world closer.

*Read more on pages 10 & 11.*

### Nature's Ultimate Survivors

In 2019, Israel's Beresheet mission carried thousands of tardigrades—microscopic “water bears”—to the Moon. Though the spacecraft crashed, some scientists believe these resilient creatures could still survive in a dormant state. Able to endure extreme heat, cold, radiation, and even the vacuum of space, tardigrades reveal the astonishing limits of life. Their secret? Cryptobiosis, a sleep-like state that halts metabolism for years. This article explores the biology, history, and spacefaring adventures of these tiny survivors, reminding us how life can persist in the most unlikely places.

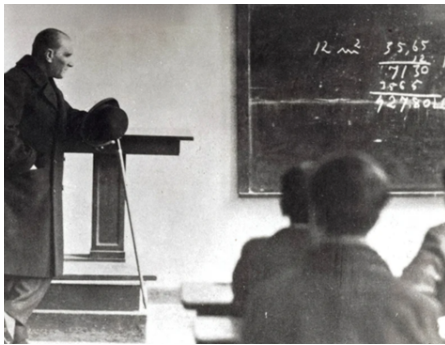
*Read more on pages 8 & 9.*



## Educational Policies & Structural Transformation During the Atatürk Era

by *Fatih Selçuk*

Following the proclamation of the Republic, the education system underwent a structural transformation in line with the ideological and economic needs of the new state. Mustafa Kemal Atatürk's educational policy was based on the objective of eliminating the fragmented structure of the late Ottoman Empire and establishing a centralized, secular, and pragmatic system. This process positioned education directly as a tool for state-building.



The first legal step in centralizing the system was the Law on the Unification of Education (Tevhid-i Tedrisat Kanunu), adopted on March 3, 1924. With this law, all educational institutions in the country were placed under the control of the Ministry of National Education. Madrasas and other institutions providing religious education were closed, ending the duality between schools providing Western-style education and traditional institutions. The primary objective here was to create a uniform curriculum compliant with the standards of the new regime and to establish a state monopoly on education.

The content of education was also secularized during this

period. Religious references were gradually removed from the curriculum, replaced by an emphasis on national history and language to reinforce nation-state consciousness. The establishment of the Turkish Historical Society and the Turkish Language Association in subsequent years served the function of reflecting this ideological framework in textbooks and academic research. To address the low literacy rate, one of the most concrete problems of the period, the Alphabet Reform was implemented in 1928. The primary reason for abandoning the Arabic alphabet and transitioning to the Latin alphabet was to accelerate the learning of reading and writing and to facilitate integration with the West. Nation's Schools (Millet Mektepleri) were opened to teach the new alphabet to the adult population, and a practical literacy mobilization was conducted.

The philosophical infrastructure of the education system was built on functionality rather than theoretical rote learning. In 1924, American educational scientist John Dewey was invited to Turkey, and a report was commissioned for the restructuring of the system. Accordingly, education was targeted to contribute directly to production and economic life. Prioritizing vocational education and laying the foundations of instructor courses (structures that would later evolve into Village Institutes) to support rural development were the results of this pragmatist approach.

At the higher education level, the 1933 University Reform was implemented. The existing Darülfünun was closed on the grounds that it did not meet the expectations of the regime and could not integrate with innovations; Istanbul University was established in its place. During this process, a significant portion of the old staff was purged, foreign academics fleeing Europe were brought to Turkey and incorporated into university faculties, and higher education was redesigned according to Western standards.

One of the changes in the physical and social infrastructure was the transition to coeducation. The practice of female and male students receiving education in the same classrooms with the same curriculum was legally standardized, and gender-based school segregation was gradually abolished.

Consequently, education during the Atatürk era was reconstructed as a rational, objective, and direct state policy aimed at consolidating the foundations of the new nation-state, transmitting the regime's ideology to the masses, and training the workforce necessary for economic development, rather than prioritizing the independent personal development of individuals.



## Rid Yourself of Your Fears...

by *Handan Akyel*

I suppose all of us, even if only a little, have our fears. I can almost hear you saying yes. And what's interesting is this: it's as if everything we fear ends up happening to us—we seem to invite all our fears into our lives, don't we? If we stop and think about it, we'll see that it is we who call them forth.

Let me give you a tiny example. Say you've made coffee and you want to carry it from the kitchen to the living room without spilling it. The more your inner voice repeats, I mustn't spill it, the more, as if out of sheer defiance, that coffee spills. This is a very small example—who knows how many more there are? A student who is about to take an exam and fears getting a low grade ends up receiving one. And when we are afraid of losing someone in a relationship, we make mistake after mistake, and in the end, we lose the person we love simply because we were afraid of losing them. Sometimes it's because of a foolish word, sometimes a glance, sometimes a single act.

So what should we do?

First of all, we must rid ourselves of our fears. Because fear is a powerful emotion nourished by negative energy and dark feelings. We must constantly tell ourselves how brave and strong we are, and that we deserve the very best this life has to offer—of course, we must say it with true belief, without the slightest doubt. We must never be afraid. Even when they tell you that you cannot succeed and that you should give up, you must tell yourself that you have the strength to overcome everything, that you will succeed, that you deserve to love and to be loved.

When you walk into an exam, repeat to yourself that you know the answers to all the questions and that you will receive the grade you deserve. If you are in a relationship, instead of asking, Will it end? Will I lose them? say, I am happy. We are happy. Even if it isn't perfect, even if there are flaws, I am in a relationship that makes me feel good.

When you show your fears the door, you will notice the change within yourself and within your life. Let go of complaining and let go of fear. Believe in yourself and trust yourself. Never allow your fears to gnaw at you, to destroy you, to drain your life away.

Look up at the sky and take deep breaths. Give yourself a chance. In life, everyone deserves a second chance—and you are the one who deserves it most. Come on, let today be the first day of your new life. Remember, you have only one life...



## İzmir Weather Forecast

for *Monday, March 2nd & Tuesday, March 3rd*

Today in İzmir will be mostly sunny and pleasant with clear skies expected throughout the day. Temperatures will rise to around **15–16 °C** in the afternoon, while early morning and late-night lows will be cooler, dropping to about **2–5 °C**. There's very low chance of rain, and winds are expected to be light, making it a

nice day for outdoor activities, especially in the midday sun.

Tomorrow's weather will remain generally mild and mostly dry, but you can expect a few more clouds moving in compared to today. Highs should again reach the mid-teens (around **16 °C**), with overnight lows around **6–7 °C**.

Conditions will still be suitable for spending time outdoors, although cloud cover might be a bit more noticeable during parts of the day.

If you'll be out and about, a light jacket or sweater is recommended especially in the morning and evening when temperatures are cooler.





## Mirror, Mirror, Tell Me: “Who Am I Not?”

by Gökçe Yüksel

*You flee from the mirror,  
my dear;  
It is only you—  
you are the one you fear, I know!*  
— **Mevlana (Mesnevi, III:3442)**

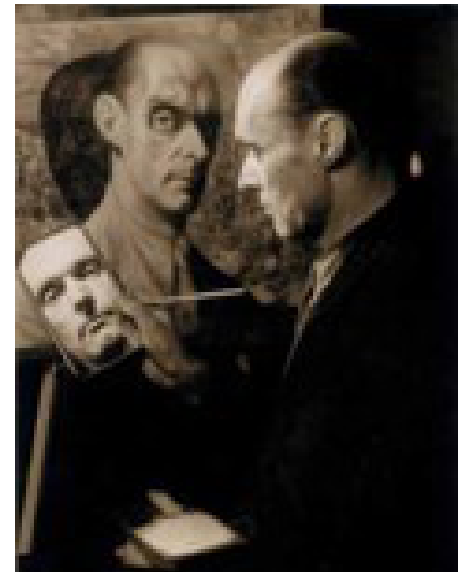
With their eyes, human beings can gather information about the world that surrounds them; yet unless they encounter a reflection, they cannot see themselves. This condition transforms the mirror into a mystical object—one that generates metaphors in art and language. Reflective surfaces are the first objects through which we can collect knowledge about ourselves. Just as a person cannot see their own face directly, they cannot see their own inner being. Behind the eyes that gaze back at us from our reflection lies a secret waiting to be discovered. For this reason, every encounter with a mirror is the first step of a journey of discovery.

The association of the mirror with identity and otherness plays a crucial conceptual role in humanity's effort to know itself and to situate itself within the universe. Thus, the mirror creates an important field of inquiry for artists. According to Jean Baudrillard's theory of simulation, we have now entered “an age of simulation in which we no longer have any relation to the real or to truth” (2010, p.15). In this new era, “media practices have reorganized our senses of space and time” (Madan Sarup, 2004, p.234). Today, the reality a person

sees in the mirror has become even more ambiguous. If what I see is not real, then what is reality? Mirrors teach us to question everything we look at and believe we see. Therefore, perhaps today more than ever, one must look into mirrors.

In a 1991 interview, Barbara Kruger states: “I dare to guess that many people listen to their mirrors at least five times a day, and that this vigilance can certainly structure both physical and psychic identity.” In this place where we attempt to understand the self and the other, we must persist in looking into the mirror. For “Through the mirror we become aware of ourselves and of others; we understand. And to understand is to place oneself in another's position—to rediscover the self within the you” (Kocabiyik, 2014, p.36).

The mirror is where the artist's reckoning with their own image begins. It is the first surface upon which a self-portrait appears before it is transferred to canvas. In a photograph of the Surrealist German painter Richard Oelze, we observe the artist in three distinct forms: his reflection in the mirror, his portrait incorporating his shadow, and his image captured in the photograph itself. Which of these three representations can reflect the artist's reality as it truly is?



**Figure 1.** Rudolf Dudenhoff, 1948, *Photograph of the Painter Richard Oelze. Artifexinopere.*  
Accessed: 11.07.2022.

Even if artists take a mirror as their reference, what they capture in their self-portraits is a different kind of reflection—both resembling and not resembling. In one sense, the image includes what lies behind the visible. It seizes us and intimates that there is more than what appears.

Artists demand more than what the mirror offers us. They take it upon themselves to lift the curtains, to thrust before our eyes what we do not wish to see. As if seeking to reveal the secret behind the mirror, Michelangelo Pistoletto staged a performance in 2016. He shattered 23 mirrors installed in a space with a sledgehammer; on the back surfaces of the broken mirrors, different colors became visible. On each of them, the word “respect” was written in the most widely spoken languages of the world.





Figure 2. Michelangelo Pistoletto, 2016, *Respect*. E-skop. Accessed: 11.10.2022.

Since 1962, Pistoletto has produced works born from his relationship with the mirror. For the artist, the mirror is a field of self-recognition, inquiry, and interrogation. In a conversation with the British art critic Jonathan Jones, Pistoletto says: “To make a self-portrait, the artist always needs a mirror. I was searching for my identity. Who am I? I needed a mirror to see myself, and over time I realized that what I was searching for was the mirror itself.”

Barbara Kruger’s *You Are Not Yourself* (1981) lays this illusion bare in the shards of a broken mirror. According to critics, the woman’s fragmented reflection is an image of the inherently fragmented existence of women in society. Women are forced to assume contradictory roles in order to meet the expectations of others. Yet when she has the chance to look into the mirror, she realizes that what is reflected back is not herself. Kruger employs bold graphic techniques to unsettle not only the woman in the mirror but also the viewer. The small size of the word “not” suggests that society attempts to convince women that they are indeed “themselves.” The necessity of tracing “a femininity that somehow has always already existed, fixed, and therefore

capable of being revealed at some point in history independent of context” is represented among the signs in Kruger’s work (Peterson & Mathews, 2008, p.69).



Figure 3. Barbara Kruger, 1981, *You Are Not Yourself*. Wikipedia. Accessed: 11.10.2022.

To the one who asks, “Who am I?” the mirror first reveals its veil—who one is not. We move from the self that we are toward the self we wish to become, lifting curtains along the way. For “Our gaze changes us, and with every look at ourselves, the one we see is already a slightly older version of us (...)” (Kocabişik, 2014, p.308). In this sense, the human being is the creation of oneself.

For Jacques Lacan, “Everything that exists in the world behaves like a mirror” (2013, p.49). Yet especially the ‘other’ is the space in which we see our own existence and position ourselves—it is, in the fullest sense, a veil-mirror. “The subject ideally constitutes itself in the Other (...) Yet it undoubtedly sees itself in the field of the Other, and the point from which it looks at itself is also within this field.”

Plato expresses the idea of the other as a mirror through a different line of reasoning. To see is as essential as to be seen in this mirroring. In Alcibiades, he recounts the following dialogue between Socrates and Alcibiades: Socrates: ...Is there not in the eye that enables us to see something like what exists in a mirror?

*Alcibiades: There is.*

*Socrates: Surely you have noticed that when one person looks into another’s eye, his face appears in the other’s eye as in a mirror. We call this part the pupil, for within it appears the image of the one who looks.*

*Alcibiades: True.*

*Socrates: Then, if one eye looks into another eye—into its finest part, the part by which it sees—it can see itself.*

According to Socrates, in order to see myself, I must look into the ‘part of the other that sees me.’ I must be seen as I see. The “words of others” that make me speak and think are mirrors held up before me.





## Big Goal: Teknofest and the International Arena

by Irmak Yılmaz Dakak

Our teams are developing their projects for TEKNOFEST, Türkiye's largest technology festival. Every sensor is being tested, every line of code is written and optimized over and over again.



Our students, who are preparing not only for national but also international coding olympiads, are practically giving their brains a workout in the world of algorithms. Their problem-solving speed is increasing, and their logical thinking muscles are getting stronger!

We are no longer just participating in competitions.

We compete to make a statement. Our goal: The summit!

Our students continue their preparations for TEKNOFEST, one of the most prestigious technology organizations in our country. Our teams are developing projects, writing algorithms, and testing their systems. There is excitement in every line of code and determination in every attempt!

And that's not all...



Our students preparing for international coding olympiads are getting ready to test themselves on a global scale in problem-solving, algorithmic thinking, and software development.

### Coding Minds, Designing Hands, A Producing Generation!

In some schools, lessons are taught.

In our school, the future is written. This year, our Information Technologies and Software classes have practically transformed into a technology base. Our students continue their work at full speed—not as a generation that merely dreams, but as one that codes its dreams.

**From LEGO to Robotics, From Arduino to Smart Systems, there is nothing ordinary in our workshop.**

- Smart vehicles designed with LEGO
- Electronic circuits built with Arduino
- Sensor-based robotic systems
- Mechanisms controlled by code

Our students learn engineering thinking by experiencing it firsthand. While building a circuit, they learn patience. While running a robot, they discover determination. While solving an error, they develop analytical thinking.





## We Are a Producing Generation, Not a Consuming One

We are shaping students who do not only use technology, but develop it.

In this classroom:

- Questions are asked.
- Solutions are sought.
- Code is written.

- Mistakes are made.
- Attempts are repeated.
- And in the end, success is achieved.
- Because we know that
- the future is not built with ready-made packages, but with written code.

## Our Message to the Future Is Clear

The students who build vehicles with LEGO, set up circuits with Arduino, and write algorithms today will become tomorrow's engineers, software architects, and technology leaders.

And we firmly believe:

The future will belong not to those who only dream, but to those who code their dreams.

## The Bitter Balance Sheet of 18th and 19th Century Foreign Policy

by *Fatih Selçuk*

Historical facts do not tolerate romantic fictions. The foreign policy of the Ottoman Empire in the 18th and 19th centuries is not a diplomatic genius to be boasted of; it is the result of military bankruptcy, economic collapse, and continuous concessions granted to imperialist powers to keep the state afloat. This two-hundred-year period merely consists of an entity that had completely lost its power attempting to postpone its inevitable de facto liquidation by taking refuge in the conflicts of interest among major states.

### The 18th Century: Confession of Military Collapse and Compulsory Diplomacy

The Ottoman discovery of diplomacy as a state policy was not an intellectual enlightenment, but an imposition of heavy defeats on the battlefields. The territorial losses starting with Karlowitz in 1699 were concrete proof that the state could no longer protect its borders with its own military power. Throughout this century, the fundamental foreign policy turned into a scramble to “maintain the status quo.”

### The 19th Century: Semi-Colonization Under the Guise of “Balance Policy”

By the 19th century, Ottoman foreign policy had completely surrendered to a mechanism called the “balance policy.” However, this concept does not signify strategic playmaking, but rather the necessity of using one imperialist state as a shield against another. The state was able to maintain its existence not through its own intrinsic power, but because Britain, France, and Russia could not agree on how to partition it.



The 1774 Treaty of Küçük Kaynarca was the heaviest toll of this process. The Black Sea's status as a Turkish lake ended, Crimea was lost, and Russia gained the right to intervene directly in the state's internal affairs under the pretext of being the protector of the Orthodox Ottoman subjects. The former condescending attitude that looked down on Europe was replaced by an existential fear and the necessity of finding European allies.

The clearest indicator of this impotence was the rebellion of the Governor of Egypt, Muhammad Ali Pasha of Kavala. Unable to stop the army of its own governor and facing the danger of losing the capital Istanbul, the Ottoman Empire begged for military aid from its enemy, Russia, and subsequently sought refuge under the protection of Britain.



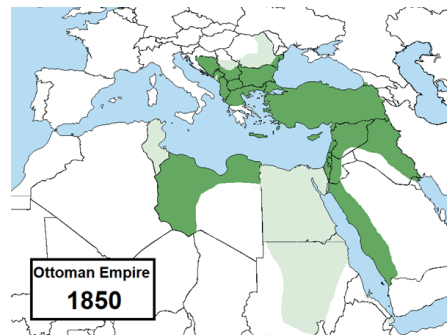


## The Sale of Economic Independence and Bankruptcy

Concessions granted to foreign powers to prolong political life resulted in the virtual destruction of the economy. The 1838 Treaty of Balta Liman, signed to secure Britain's political support, threw Ottoman markets wide open to European goods tariff-free. This move dealt a fatal blow to domestic industry and production, turning the state into an open reservoir of raw materials and a market.

Political and military dependence brought financial dependence along with it. In the Crimean War of 1853-1856, the state entered the war against Russia with the support of Britain and France. When the first foreign loans taken to cover the costs of the war went into palace construction and current expenditures instead of production, the state went

bankrupt. With the Decree of Muharram in 1881, the Ottoman Public Debt Administration (Düyun-u Umumiye) was established, and the management of the state's most fundamental revenue sources passed directly into the hands of European creditors. Economic sovereignty was officially handed over.



## Axis Shift: The Operation of Changing Masters

In the last quarter of the 19th century (after the 1878 Treaty of Berlin), when Britain abandoned its policy of protecting Ottoman territorial integrity, the state was forced to find a new patron. The policy of aligning with Germany

implemented during the reign of Abdul Hamid II was not an independent political maneuver; it was an attempt to enter under the umbrella of German imperialism against the pressure of Russia and Britain. Handing over railway concessions and economic resources to the Germans resulted in nothing more than a change of address for the dependency.

## Conclusion

When 18th and 19th-century foreign policy is examined objectively, there is no success to be found. This period is a process in which massive territorial losses were experienced, demographic crises erupted, economic and financial sovereignty was surrendered to foreign capital, and a state with a collapsed army was reduced to a semi-colonial status. The "balance policy" is the deathbed throes of an empire, packaged in the language of diplomacy. The only reality is the de facto collapse of the state.

# A Creature from Space Might Be Looking at You

by *Zeynep Ece Demir (9A)*

In 2019, a spacecraft called Beresheet was sent to the Moon by Israel. During this mission, thousands of tardigrades—also known as water bears—were placed inside the spacecraft. Unfortunately, the vehicle crashed while trying to land. Even so, some scientists believe that a number of these extremely tough creatures could still be there in a dormant state.

Tardigrades are microscopic animals that are usually between 0.5 and 1.5 millimeters long. They

have eight short legs with tiny claws, and they move very slowly under a microscope. In fact, the name "tardigrada" means "slow walker" in Latin. Their bodies look round and slightly chubby, and their heads can move a little separately from their bodies. Some species even have very simple eyes. They usually live in moss, damp soil, and thin layers of water. What is really interesting is how common they are—you can find them in many different places on Earth, even in very harsh environments.

What makes water bears so famous is their amazing durability. Tardigrades can survive temperatures as high as about 150°C. They can also live through extreme cold close to -272°C, which is very near absolute zero. In addition, they can tolerate strong radiation that would kill most other living things. In several experiments, tardigrades exposed directly to the vacuum of space managed to survive. Some of the ones sent to the International Space Station even came back to Earth and continued living and



reproducing normally. Because of this, scientists are still studying how their cells and DNA stay protected.

The secret behind their survival is a process called cryptobiosis. When conditions become dangerous, tardigrades lose most of the water in their bodies and enter a sleep-like state called the “tun” form. In this mode, their metabolism almost completely stops and they use almost no energy. Normally these animals would not live very long, but in the tun state they can survive for months or even years. There are recorded cases of tardigrades coming back to life after about 30 years. Because of this, some researchers think the tardigrades on the Moon might still be able

to wake up if the right conditions were provided, although this is not proven.

Tardigrades were first discovered in 1773 by the German zoologist Johann August Ephraim Goeze. When he saw the creature under a microscope, he thought it looked like a tiny bear. Later, the Italian scientist Lazzaro Spallanzani studied them more carefully and officially introduced the name “tardigrada.” Since then, water bears have continued to attract scientists who want to understand the real limits of life.

## The End of A King: The French Monarchy Ends

by Yonca Turuşlar (11A)

### Paris, January 1793

The great revolution that began in 1789 has reached an irreversible point in French history. Once an absolute ruler, King Louis XVI of France was executed by decision of the National Convention. This event marked not only the end of a monarch but the definitive collapse of centuries of monarchy in France.

### From Absolute Power to Crisis

By the late 18th century, France faced a severe economic crisis. National debts were rising, and war expenses drained the treasury. Ordinary citizens suffered under heavy taxes while the nobility and clergy enjoyed privileges. Rising bread prices created widespread unrest in Paris.

In 1789, the Estates-General convened, and representatives of the Third Estate formed

the National Assembly. The storming of the Bastille became a symbol of resistance and marked the beginning of the French Revolution. The Revolution was no longer just about reforms—it represented a complete social and political change.

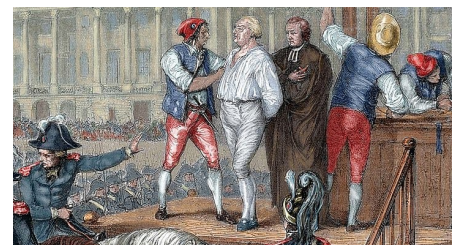
### The Flight to Varennes: A Loss of Trust

By 1791, the king’s relationship with the people had weakened. Although Louis XVI outwardly accepted the constitutional monarchy, he was uncomfortable with the Revolution’s direction. Restrictions on royal power and the loss of the monarchy’s former influence caused unrest within the royal court.

On the night of June 20, 1791, the king and his family secretly left Paris. Their goal was to reach the eastern border of France, join loyal military forces, and possibly

restore royal authority. They dressed plainly to avoid attention. However, the plan failed. During the journey, the king was recognized because his image appeared on coins. In the town of Varennes, a local official identified him, and authorities quickly intervened, stopping the royal family.

Their return to Paris was not a triumphant homecoming but a humiliating defeat. After Varennes, many French people believed definitively that the king was against the Revolution. The idea of a republic gained momentum. Historians often cite Varennes as the true beginning of the monarchy’s collapse.





## The Monarchy Formally Ends

On August 10, 1792, the people stormed the Tuileries Palace. After the clashes, the king's powers were suspended. Shortly thereafter, the monarchy was officially abolished, and France was declared a Republic. Louis was no longer "King" but referred to as an ordinary citizen under the name "Louis Capet."



### Trial and Execution

In December 1792, the National Convention began the trial of the former king. He was accused of treason and conspiring with foreign powers. Debates were intense. Some deputies argued for exile or imprisonment, while radicals claimed execution was necessary to protect the Revolution.

By a narrow vote, Louis XVI was found guilty and sentenced to death. On January 21, 1793, he was executed by guillotine in front of a crowd in Paris. The event shocked Europe—this was one of the first times a reigning king had been tried and executed by his own people.



### The Queen and The Children

Louis's wife, Queen Marie Antoinette, was also put on trial for treason. She was executed on October 16, 1793.

The royal couple had four children, but only two survived at the time:

**Marie-Thérèse Charlotte (their daughter):** She was imprisoned but not executed. In 1795, she was

released and sent to Austria, where she lived in exile.

**Louis-Charles (their young son):** After his father's death, some royalists recognized him as "Louis XVII." However, he was imprisoned in harsh conditions and died in 1795 at the age of ten due to illness and neglect.

These events demonstrated that the French Revolution was not only a political upheaval but also a complete collapse of a royal family.

### The Beginning of a New Era

The tragic end of Louis XVI and his family marks one of the most significant turning points of the French Revolution. What began as a movement for "Liberty, Equality, Fraternity" had now completely overturned the old order.

France entered a monarchy-free era, while European monarchies were deeply affected by these developments. The Revolution had begun a process that would reshape not just one nation but the political future of the entire continent.

## Cultures Beyond Borders

by Gizem Eroğlu

Growing up in an international school means you are already part of a world without borders. Different cultures, languages, and experiences are not something distant for you — they are part

of your everyday life. During my time in Hungary, I worked as an Intercultural Assistant. You might wonder what such a job involves. My role was to support people from different cultural

backgrounds as they adapted to life in a new country. I helped them understand the school system, daily routines, social expectations, and cultural differences while supporting their integration into a





new environment. This experience taught me how understanding and respecting different cultures can help build inclusive communities, a lesson I carry with me every day. One of my main responsibilities was helping schools become truly international spaces. This meant encouraging students from different cultures to communicate, learn together, and feel safe and comfortable in the classroom. Creating an environment where everyone feels respected and understood was at the heart of this experience.

Living abroad taught me how cultural differences shape everyday behaviour. For instance, in Türkiye, eating loudly in public would feel rude to me, but my Asian friends explained that in their culture, making noise while eating shows appreciation for the food. This taught me that what

seems impolite or strange in one culture can be completely normal in another.

While living in Hungary, I also observed how social norms vary in public life. Some behaviours that initially felt unfamiliar to me were perfectly normal there. These experiences helped me understand that there is no single “correct” way of behaving — cultural context matters. At the same time, I noticed something very familiar: hospitality. Just like in Türkiye, people made great efforts to make guests feel welcome, showing that kindness and warmth are shared values across cultures.

Living in the UK further changed my understanding of daily social interactions. I was surprised by how frequently people said “sorry,” even when situations were not their fault. Respecting queues

was another important social rule, visible everywhere from bus stops to coffee shops. These small habits showed me that culture often appears not in grand traditions, but in simple everyday actions.

Food also revealed unexpected cultural connections. I grew up with my mother’s homemade tomato paste, known as salça, a tradition filled with family memories. When speaking with my Italian friend Federicca, she told me that in Sicily she prepares la salsa with her grandmother following the same family traditions. Later, my Bosnian friend Jelena shared that what we call salça, she calls ajvar, and her grandmother even sends some to me every year. Sharing these stories — and sometimes the food itself — showed me that family, tradition, and connection exist in every culture.

Learning languages opened many doors for me. Speaking English not only allowed me to travel and build friendships but also helped me see the world from different perspectives. Each language carries its own way of thinking, helping us communicate and understand one another more deeply.

You may already experience this cultural exchange every day in our school corridors, classrooms, and friendships. Being part of an international school means learning one of life’s most valuable lessons: understanding people beyond borders. When we learn from each other’s cultures, the world does not become larger— it becomes closer and more unified.





***Thank you for reading,  
and supporting the ICS  
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